“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 15

A Brief Description of the Boyhood Pastimes

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 “I worship Caitanya Prabhu. The mere offering of flowers at His lotus feet turns even an evil mind into a good one.” (Hari-bhakti-vilāsa, 7.1)[1]

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 Now I shall give a brief account of the Lord’s boyhood pastimes. In those years His chief occupation was study.[2]

4 “The boyhood pastimes of Caitanya-Kṛṣṇa are vast and enchanting. They begin with His first lessons and end with His marriage.”[3]

5 He studied grammar with Gaṅgādāsa Paṇḍita, and as soon as He heard the sūtras and their commentaries, He knew them all by heart.[4]

6 Within a short time He mastered the *Pañjī-ṭīkā*, and, young as He was, He defeated students who had studied for years.[5]

7 In the *Caitanya-maṅgala* Vṛndāvana dāsa has described in detail the Lord’s pastimes as a student.[6]

8 One day the Lord bowed at His mother's feet and said, "Mother, grant Me one gift."

9 "I will give You whatever You ask," said His mother, and the Lord replied, "Do not eat grain on Ekādaśī."[7]

10 Śacī said, "I will not eat it. You have spoken well." And from that day on she observed Ekādaśī.

11 Then Miśra, seeing that Viśvarūpa had come of age, resolved to find Him a bride and see Him married.

12 When Viśvarūpa heard of this, He fled from home. He took sannyāsa and set out on pilgrimage to the holy places.

13 The news filled the hearts of Śacī and Miśra with sorrow, and the Lord set about consoling His mother and father.

14 "It is well that Viśvarūpa has taken sannyāsa: He has delivered both His father's line and His mother's.[8]

15 "And I Myself will serve you both." Hearing this, His father and mother were content at heart.

16 One day, after chewing betel that had been offered to the Deity, the Lord fell to the ground unconscious.

17 His father and mother hastily sprinkled water on His face, and when He came to Himself, the Lord told them a wondrous tale.

18 "Viśvarūpa took Me away from here and said to Me, 'You must take sannyāsa.'

19 “I answered, ‘My father and mother have no one to look after them, and I am still a boy — what do I know of sannyāsa?

20 “ ‘As a householder I shall serve My father and mother, and this will please Lakṣmī-Nārāyaṇa.’

21 “Then Viśvarūpa sent Me back here and asked Me to convey His obeisances to Mother, millions upon millions of them.”

22 Thus Gaurahari revels in many pastimes, and why He does so, I cannot understand.

23 Some time later Miśra left this world, and grief welled up in the hearts of mother and son.[9]

24 Friends and kinsmen came and consoled them both, and the Lord performed His father’s funeral rites as the scriptures enjoin.

25 After a while the Lord thought to Himself, “I have become a householder; now I must take up the duties of household life.

26 “Yet without a wife household life has no grace.” Thinking thus, He set His mind on marriage.

27 “It is not the house that is called the home; the wife is called the home. Together with her one attains all the goals of life.”[10]

28 One day, by providence, as the Lord was coming home from His studies, He saw the daughter of Vallabhācārya on the way to the Gaṅgā.

29 The love that had been theirs from of old awoke in them both, and, as providence would have it, Vanamālī the matchmaker came to Śacī’s

house.[11]

30 At a sign from Śacī he arranged the match, and her son married Lakṣmī.

31 Vṛndāvana dāsa has described all this in detail; here I have set out the boyhood pastimes in outline.[12]

32 The Lord's boyhood holds pastimes of many kinds, and Vṛndāvana dāsa has told them at length.

33 Therefore I have given here no more than a glimpse of them; through the *Caitanya-maṅgala* they have become famous throughout the world.

34 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. A play on words: *sumanas* means both "flower" and "good mind". Heading in the edition: "By the worship of Gaura even the evil-minded gain a good mind." *Anubhāṣya*: an evil mind is one absorbed in anything other than Kṛṣṇa; a good mind is free of other desires, uncovered by knowledge and karma, and wholly given to the service of Kṛṣṇa. ↩
2. *Anubhāṣya* (on 15.4): *paugaṇḍa*, boyhood, is the period from the fifth year of life to the tenth. Heading in the edition: "Among the boyhood pastimes, study is the chief." ↩
3. *Anubhāṣya*: Caitanya-Kṛṣṇa is Viśvambhara, the Lord whose form is one with Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa. ↩
4. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the Lord first received His elementary schooling from Viṣṇu and Sudarśana, and then studied grammar with Gaṅgādāsa Paṇḍita. ↩
5. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the *Pañjī-ṭīkā* was a well-known commentary on grammar, and Mahāprabhu wrote His own notes (*ṭippanī*) on it. ↩
6. *Caitanya-maṅgala* is the original title of the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (cf. Ādi 8.33–35). *Anubhāṣya*: see *Caitanya-bhāgavata*, Ādi 4 and 6–10. ↩

7. *Anubhāṣya*: in the *Bhakti-sandarbha* (299) Śrī Jīva Gosvāmī cites the *Skanda Purāṇa* and the *Agni Purāṇa*: to eat on Ekādaśī is a grave sin, and the fast on that day is the great vow of the Vaiṣṇavas, binding even on those who are not Vaiṣṇavas. Vaiṣṇavas never eat anything but mahā-prasāda, and so for them the Ekādaśī fast means giving up grains, even as *mahā-prasāda*. ↩
8. Heading in the edition: “When a son takes sannyāsa for the worship of Kṛṣṇa, the lines of his mother and father are delivered.” ↩
9. Heading in the edition: “Miśra’s disappearance from the world of men.” The *Anubhāṣya* cites the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Ādi 8): Miśra’s eternally perfect body passed from sight; the Lord wept bitterly for him, as Śrī Rāma wept at the passing of Daśaratha; to tell of this at length is painful, and so the author tells it briefly. ↩
10. In the edition the verse is headed “[A saying of smṛti (of the Lord?)]”; the *Anubhāṣya* refers to the *Mahābhārata* (Śānti-parva, 144.6). The goals of life (*puruṣārtha*), according to the *Anubhāṣya*, are dharma, artha, kāma, mokṣa and the rest. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: it is not the dwelling but the wife that is called the home; together with the wife one enjoys all the goals of life. ↩
11. *Anubhāṣya*: Vanamālī the matchmaker was a brāhmaṇa of Navadvīpa who arranged the Lord’s marriage. *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* (49): Viśvāmitra, the matchmaker at Śrī Rāma’s wedding, and the brāhmaṇa whom Rukmiṇī sent to Śrī Kṛṣṇa are both now Vanamālī, who for this service came to be called Ācārya. ↩
12. *Anubhāṣya*: see *Caitanya-bhāgavata*, Ādi 10; Ādi 8 there describes at greater length the Lord’s sacred-thread ceremony (*upanayana*) and the gold He gave His mother. ↩